Trusted Negotiation & Deal-Closing Platform — Market, Competitor & Gap Audit

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Executive summary

Build it, as a deal room that closes deals people have already found, not as another marketplace. No product in India takes two strangers from first offer to released payment, and the incumbents are not paid to do it.

- The problem. Deals are negotiated in calls and chat, then closed with an unprotected advance. Cheating-related cyber fraud cost Indians about ₹19,813 crore in 2025, and MSMEs wait 73 days on average to be paid.
- The gap. OLX and IndiaMART connect people but stay out of the transaction. Trustap and Escrow.com cannot pay Indian sellers in rupees. Castler, Pactum and Procol serve enterprises, and Upwork keeps about 19% of deal value while covering mainly its own marketplace.
- The product. HaathMila (working name): versioned offers, an agreement generated from the accepted offer and signed by OTP, money held by Razorpay until delivery is accepted, evidence-backed disputes, a portable trust profile, and a Claude copilot in Tamil, Hindi and English.
- The wedge. MSME orders, job work and project deals of ₹25,000 to ₹25 lakh in Coimbatore, starting with your own ElectronIx deals. Used goods between individuals come in phase 2.
- The model. Free to negotiate and sign; 1.5% of each funded milestone (minimum ₹49, cap ₹4,999) plus payment cost at actuals; Business Pro at ₹999 a month.
- The risks. Getting counterparties to join, getting strong buyers to pre-fund, payment-partner approval, and fraud. Each has a mitigation and an early-warning metric below.
- Next step. Get lawyer and CA opinions and Razorpay approval for held payments while Claude Code builds phases 0 to 4 on mocks.

Decisions I made for you

You asked me to decide on my own, so I locked ten choices to make the research and the build prompt specific. Each is reversible, and the build prompt keeps most of them as configuration.

#	Decision	My choice	Why
1	Market	India first: INR, Indian KYC, payments and law. Other countries later.	Your base and network. Indian payment, e-sign and tax rules shape the whole product.
2	Product shape	A deal room, not a classifieds site. Two parties who met anywhere (WhatsApp, Instagram, OLX, IndiaMART, LinkedIn, referrals) negotiate, sign, pay and close inside one shareable link.	Skips the empty-marketplace problem. Every deal invites the other side, so each user brings the next one. Listings come in phase 3.
3	First customers	High-value B2B and project deals: MSME orders, job work, fabrication and automation projects, freelance and agency work, from ₹25,000 to ₹25 lakh.	Biggest trust gap: advance-payment fraud on one side, late payment on the other. Multi-term deals are where structure beats chat. Your Coimbatore network can supply the first 50 businesses.
4	Second segment	High-value used goods between individuals (phones, laptops, bikes, machinery), phase 2.	Large fraud problem, but it needs inspection and logistics partners first.
5	Money	The platform never holds funds. The buyer pays an RBI-authorised payment aggregator; the seller's share is held and released on acceptance (Razorpay Route "on hold"). A bank escrow partner later for very large tickets.	Holding other people's money needs RBI authorisation. An authorised aggregator's escrow account keeps us out of that.
6	Identity	Tiered: phone OTP, then PAN and bank-account check, then DigiLocker or Aadhaar through a licensed KYC provider; GSTIN or Udyam for businesses. No Aadhaar numbers stored.	Trust badges people understand, and sensitive data stays out of our database.
7	Agreement	Every accepted offer becomes a hashed PDF agreement signed with OTP. Aadhaar eSign in phase 2.	A binding record without paperwork, ready if a dispute comes.

#	Decision	My choice	Why
8	AI	A Claude-powered copilot: summaries, counter-offer suggestions inside your private limits, risky-term flags, Tamil, Hindi and English translation. A human confirms every offer.	Real help for first-time negotiators, without an agent making commitments on anyone's behalf.
9	Stack	Next.js 16 (App Router) and Supabase (Postgres, Auth, Realtime, Storage, cron) on Vercel, database in Mumbai. Deal rules live in Postgres functions.	Your requested stack. Rules in Postgres keep the core portable to your Rust/Axum stack later.
10	Working name	HaathMila ("shook hands"). haathmila.com and haathmila.in were unregistered on 30 Oct 2026; Karaar and Vaada are backups (.app free).	Short, pan-India, and it says "deal done". Run a trademark search before buying.

Ground analysis: where online deals break today

Indians already negotiate online at huge scale, but the negotiation happens in calls and chat, and the deal ends with an unprotected payment. Trust breaks at the hand-offs: from talk to terms, terms to money, and money to delivery.

How a typical deal runs today:

1. Find: a listing or lead on OLX, IndiaMART, Instagram, Facebook, LinkedIn, or a referral.
2. Negotiate: phone calls and WhatsApp. No versioned record of price, scope, delivery date or warranty.
3. Agree: a verbal "OK" or a PDF quotation, rarely signed by both sides.
4. Pay: UPI or NEFT straight to the other party, usually as an advance. Nobody neutral holds the money.
5. Deliver: no proof of delivery and no agreed inspection window.
6. Dispute: a police complaint, consumer court, or nothing at all.

Where it breaks	Who loses	Evidence	What removes it
Talk to terms	Both sides	Price, scope and dates live in calls and chats, so "that's not what we agreed" has no answer.	Structured, versioned offers with a visible diff per round
Terms to commitment	Both sides	Quotations are rarely countersigned; nothing binds either side.	Accepted offer becomes an OTP-signed, hashed agreement
Commitment to money	Buyer	IndiaMART says it does not take part in transactions; its Payment Protection covers only Trust Seal suppliers, up to ₹5,00,000 (IndiaMART help). Police advice for classifieds: avoid advance payments, treat urgency as a red flag, never scan a QR code to "receive" money (cyber advisory).	Buyer pays into a held account; seller starts work only when the deal shows "funded"
Delivery to payment	Seller	MSMEs wait 73 days on average to be paid, although 82.6% of invoices carry 0–30 day terms (Recordent 2026). Delayed payments to MSMEs stood at ₹7.34 lakh crore in March 2024 (GAME, FISME, C2FO).	Money is already held; it releases automatically when the inspection window ends
Dispute	Both sides	IndiaMART holds a 1.7/5 Trustpilot score from 506 reviews, 81% one-star; buyers report paying and never receiving goods (Trustpilot). MSME Samadhaan had ₹31,039 crore in pending delayed-payment claims in December 2025 (Swarajya).	Evidence-backed dispute flow, platform mediation, then an online dispute resolution partner

The scale is national and local. Indians lost about ₹19,813 crore across 21.77 lakh cheating-related cyber fraud complaints in 2025, and Tamil Nadu alone lost ₹1,897 crore (IANS, I4C data). Coimbatore residents lost ₹87.16 crore in 2025 (The Quint).

The insight: a better chat app does not fix this. A platform that owns every hand-off, from record to signature to held money to confirmed delivery, removes the reason for advance-payment fraud and late payment at the same time.

Market size and demand signals

The people this product serves are already negotiating online every day; what they lack is a safe way to close. Even a 0.1% share of registered MSMEs is worth roughly ₹80 crore a year in fees (estimate below).

Signal	Number	Why it matters here
Registered MSMEs (Udyam and Udyam Assist)	8.84 crore as of 30 June 2026 (KNN India)	The pool of buyers and sellers for B2B and job-work deals.
B2B enquiries that start online	2.7 crore unique business enquiries on IndiaMART in Jul–Sep 2026 (fiscal Q2 FY27) (Inc42)	Each enquiry becomes an offline negotiation, usually ending in an advance payment. That moment is our entry point.
Strangers negotiating in classifieds	About 76 million average monthly unique visitors across CarTrade's platforms, including OLX India, in Q2 FY27; OLX India revenue grew 26% year on year (CarTrade release)	Shows how many Indians bargain with strangers online each month, the phase 2 audience.
Freelance and gig workforce	7.7 million in 2020–21, projected 23.5 million by 2029–30; 22% of gig work is high-skilled (NITI Aayog)	Project work needs milestone payments, our second deal template.
Escrow demand already proven	Castler reached ₹1,000 crore of monthly transaction value in July 2022, up from ₹15 crore a year earlier (CXOToday)	People use neutral money-holding when it is easy. Nobody has put negotiation in front of it.

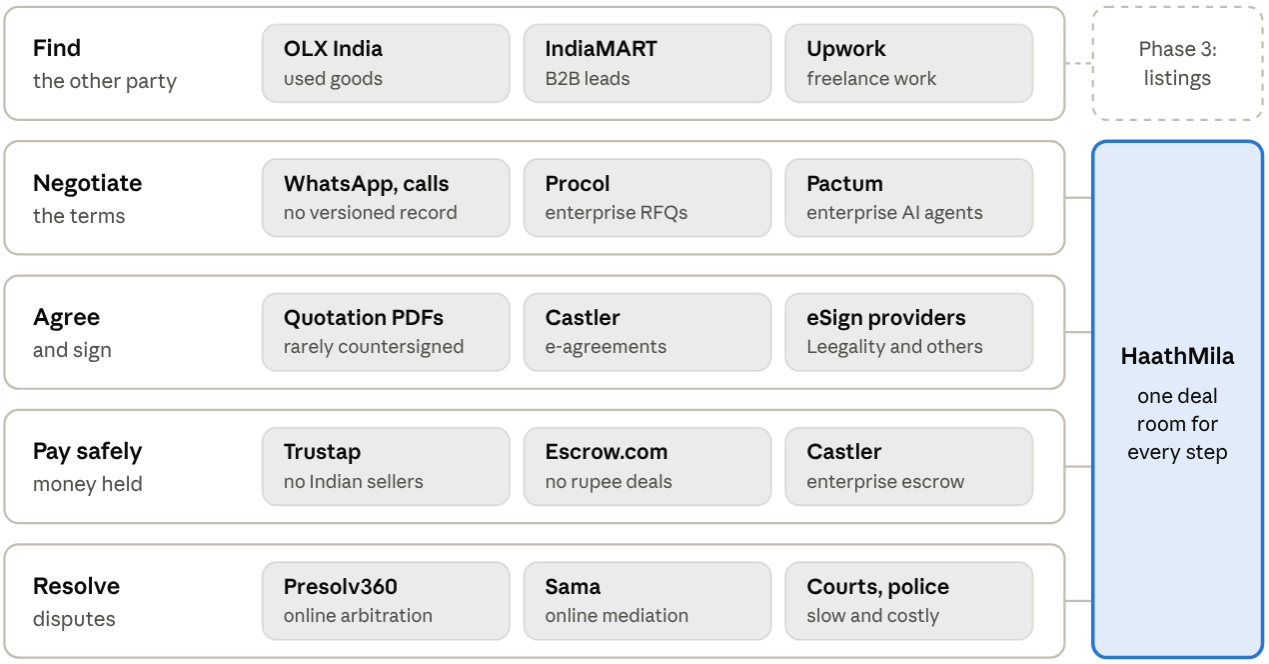
What a small share is worth (my estimate, not sourced data): 0.1% of registered MSMEs is about 88,400 businesses. If each closes 6 protected deals a year at an average of ₹1 lakh, that is ₹5,304 crore of deal value. At a 1.5% net fee, revenue is about ₹79.6 crore a year.

Competitive landscape

Competitors fall into five groups by the deal stage they serve: finding the other party, negotiating, signing, holding money, and resolving disputes.

Each player owns one link of a deal; nobody owns the whole chain

Deal stages in India and who serves each, October 2026



HaathMila covers negotiation to disputes in one room; listings come in phase 3.

market map · 5 deal stages, 15 players

Read across each row: every incumbent covers one stage, and the hand-offs between rows are where deals fail. HaathMila runs stages two to five inside one deal room.

Competitor performance

The incumbents are healthy, profitable businesses, but none is paid to make the deal itself safe. Portals are paid for connecting people, escrow players sell only the payment step, and AI negotiation is sold only to large enterprises.

Player	What it does	Latest performance	Money model and fees	Where users push back
OLX India	Used-goods classifieds, owned by CarTrade	Revenue up 26% and EBITDA up 36% year on year, Jul–Sep 2026. Segment revenue ₹55.1 crore in Jan–Mar 2026 (Inc42)	Classifieds revenue; buyer and seller pay each other directly	Advance-payment, fake-screenshot and QR-code scams are common enough that police publish OLX-specific advice (advisory)
IndiaMART	B2B lead marketplace	Revenue ₹428.6 crore (+10%), net profit ₹90.7 crore, 2.2 lakh paying suppliers, 2.7 crore enquiries, Jul–Sep 2026	Supplier subscriptions. Payment Protection only with Trust Seal suppliers, up to ₹5 lakh (help page)	Trustpilot 1.7/5 from 506 reviews: paid-but-not-delivered orders, disputes closed unresolved (Trustpilot)
Trustap	Escrow-style payments for person-to-person and marketplace deals (Ireland)	Raised $10m in June 2026, led by Aperture Capital. Trustap Index, which lets AI shopping agents negotiate and pay with human confirmation, launches later in 2026	Buyer pays 2–4% (3% online); sellers pay nothing; 24-hour complaint window (Preloved). Lists INR, but India is not a supported seller country (docs)	Trustpilot 3.6/5 from 119 reviews, 21% one-star: delayed payouts, fee kept on a cancelled deal (Trustpilot)
Escrow.com	Licensed online escrow (US)	Holds only USD, AUD, CAD, EUR and GBP; no rupees	2.6% up to $5,000 (min $50), 2.4% to $50,000, 1.9% to $200,000; cards add 3.05% (fee calculator)	Cannot be used for rupee deals inside India

Player	What it does	Latest performance	Money model and fees	Where users push back
Castler	Indian digital escrow for enterprises and banks	$6m pre-Series A (Capital 2B, Flipkart, IIFL). Claims 10 bank partners, 500+ enterprises and over ₹5,000 crore a month	Escrow accounts and an escrow banking stack sold to enterprises	Built for enterprise flows, not for two small parties closing one negotiated deal
Upwork	Global freelance marketplace with milestone escrow	2025 revenue $788m (+2.4%), gross services volume over $4bn, 785,000 active clients	Take rate 19% of deal value in Oct–Dec 2025. Freelancer fee 0–15% per contract; client fee 3–5% (Basic) or 8–10% (Business Plus); $0.99–$14.99 per new contract (Getmany)	Fees stack on both sides, and protection covers only work found on Upwork
Pactum	AI agents that negotiate supplier contracts	$54m Series C led by Insight Partners (June 2025), over $100m raised; AI-handled spend up 489%	Enterprise software for Global 2000 procurement teams	Built for large buyers; nothing for MSMEs or individuals
Procol	Indian sourcing SaaS: RFQs, reverse auctions, vendor management	Raised ₹51 crore in 2022; over 70 large enterprises and ₹7,500 crore of spend managed at the time	Enterprise subscriptions (Peak XV)	Serves the buyer's procurement team; the supplier gets no payment protection from it

One threat to watch: Trustap already lists INR and is building rails for AI agents to negotiate and pay. If it adds Indian sellers, it becomes the closest direct competitor.

Where competitors lag

Nobody covers the whole chain from first offer to released payment. Each player owns one or two links, and the hand-offs between them are where deals fail.

Player	Finds the other party	Structured offers	Signed agreement	Money held until delivery	Deals found anywhere	Rupee payments in India	Serves MSMEs and individuals
OLX India	Yes	No, chat	No	No	No	No, parties pay directly	Yes
IndiaMART	Yes	No, enquiry then calls	No	Part: Trust Seal sellers, up to ₹5 lakh	No	Part	Yes
Trustap	No	No, price agreed elsewhere	No	Yes	Yes	No Indian sellers	Yes
Escrow.com	No	No	Part: transaction terms	Yes	Yes	No INR	Yes
Castler	No	No	Yes: e-agreements	Yes	Yes	Yes	Part: mainly enterprises
Upwork	Yes	Part: proposals and offers	Part: platform contract	Yes: milestones	Part: Direct Contracts	Part: priced in USD	Yes
Pactum	No	Yes: AI agents	Part	No	No	No	No: Global 2000 only
Procol	Part: vendor network	Yes: RFQs, auctions	Part	No	No	No	No: enterprise buyers
HaathMila (plan)	Phase 3	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

My assessment from each product's public pages and the sources above; "Part" means limited or only in some cases.

The six lagging points that matter most:

1. Negotiation is unstructured. Outside enterprise procurement it happens in chat and on calls, with no versioned record of what was offered and accepted.

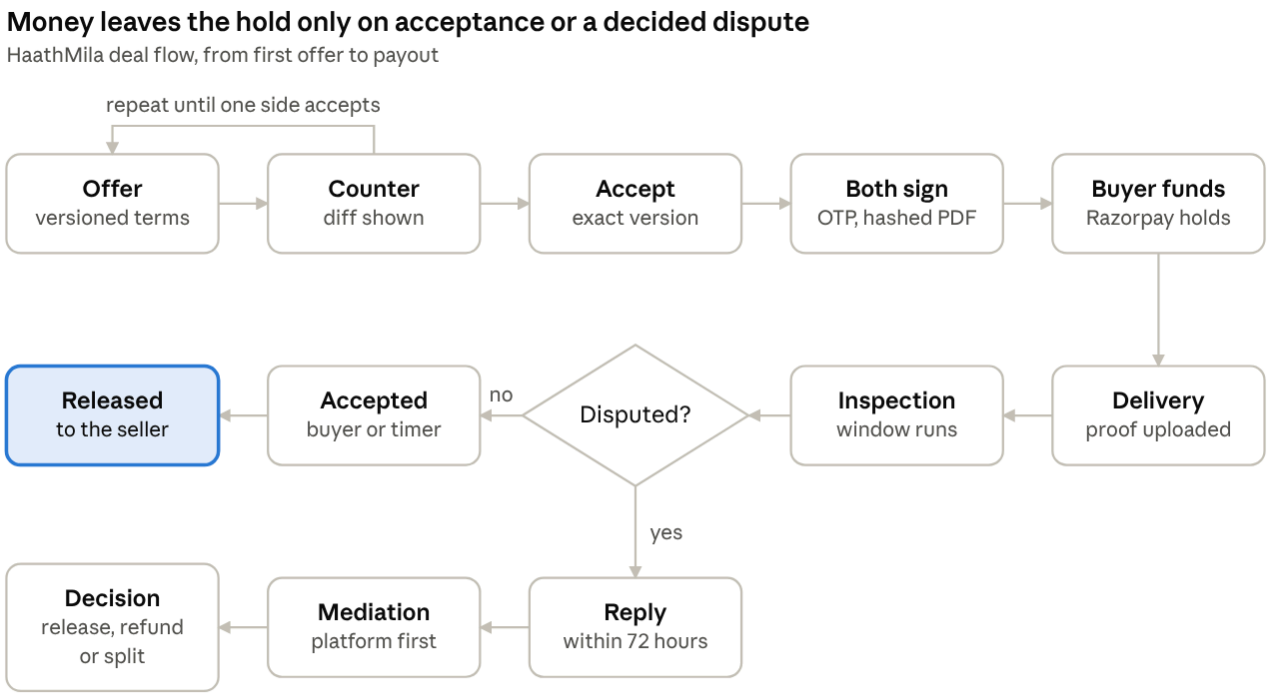
2. Payment protection is missing, rationed, foreign or enterprise-only. OLX has none, IndiaMART limits it to Trust Seal sellers up to ₹5 lakh, Trustap and Escrow.com cannot pay rupees to Indian sellers, and Castler sells to enterprises.
3. Agreement and money are disconnected. Escrow tools take a final price typed in after a negotiation that happened elsewhere, so nothing ties the held money to the agreed terms.
4. Disputes have no evidence. The chat is on WhatsApp and the payment is on UPI, so no platform can see what was agreed.
5. Fees are high or feel unfair. Upwork keeps about 19% of deal value; Trustap users complain about a buyer fee kept on cancelled deals.
6. AI negotiation help exists only for the largest buyers. Small businesses negotiate alone, often across languages.

How we close the gaps

HaathMila wins by owning the whole deal inside one link, so the money is tied to the exact terms both sides signed. Six product pillars answer the six lagging points, and four features make the lead compound.

Lagging point	HaathMila's answer	How it works in the product
Unstructured negotiation	Versioned offers	Each offer is a term sheet: price, quantity, delivery date, payment milestones, warranty, and who pays the fees. A counter shows a line-by-line diff. Offers expire (48 hours by default), and "Accept" names the exact version, so nobody accepts a stale offer.
Protection missing or rationed	Held payment on every deal, any size	The buyer funds each milestone through Razorpay. The seller's share sits on hold and the deal shows "Funded" before work starts. It releases on acceptance, or automatically when the inspection window ends.

Lagging point	HaathMila's answer	How it works in the product
Agreement and money disconnected	Agreement generated from the accepted offer	A PDF is built from the accepted terms, its SHA-256 fingerprint is shown to both sides, and each side signs with OTP. The agreement's milestones are the held milestones, so the price is never retyped.
Disputes without evidence	Evidence locker	Offers, chat, files, delivery proof and every status change go into an append-only, tamper-evident log. Path: raise within the window, the other side answers in 72 hours, platform mediation, then arbitration through an online dispute resolution provider such as Presolv360 or Sama.
High or unfair fees	Low, upfront, fair	Negotiating and signing are free. A fee applies only when money moves, payment cost is passed through at actuals, and who pays is itself a negotiable term. Our fee is refunded if a deal is cancelled before release.
AI help only for big buyers	A copilot for every user	Summaries of long threads, counter-offer suggestions inside the user's private walk-away limit (never visible to the other side), flags on risky terms, and Tamil, Hindi and English translation of messages.



deal flow · 13 steps, 1 decision

Money stays on hold from funding until the buyer accepts, the inspection window ends, or a dispute is decided, and every step is logged.

Four features that compound:

- Portable trust profile. Only funded, completed deals can be reviewed, and reviews stay hidden until both sides submit. Each user gets a public link, for example "31 deals closed, 0 disputes", to paste into WhatsApp, IndiaMART or LinkedIn.
- Deal links as the growth loop. Every deal starts with one party sending a link, and the other side must join to negotiate. Each deal recruits a new user at no acquisition cost.
- Scam shield. The chat flags UPI IDs, phone numbers, outside payment links and "pay me directly" phrases, warns both sides, and repeated attempts lower the sender's trust score.
- Price intelligence (phase 3). Anonymised accepted prices by category and city feed the copilot's "fair range" hints.

What v1 deliberately leaves out: public listings, autonomous AI agents, holding money ourselves, cash on delivery, and cross-border deals.

Beachhead, go-to-market and pricing

Start with MSME orders and project deals in Coimbatore, sell through your own network and industry associations, and charge only when protected money moves. Bengaluru's Peenya industrial cluster is the natural second city.

The first customers, in order:

1. Your own deals. Run ElectronIx quotations and project milestones through HaathMila. That gives 10 to 20 real deals and real counterparties before launch.
2. Job shops, fabricators, panel builders, automation integrators and machine dealers, and the buyers who order from them.
3. Freelancers and small agencies who serve these businesses (design, CAD, PLC programming, software), paid by milestone.

Channels that fit this market:

- Deal links. Every deal recruits the other party, so each seller onboarded brings buyers, and the reverse.
- Industry associations such as CODISSIA and SIEMA in Coimbatore: member demos, a launch offer, and dispute-handling talks.
- WhatsApp first. Rich deal-link previews and WhatsApp updates at every step, because that is where these deals already happen.
- IndiaMART sellers and buyers. Pitch HaathMila as the safe way to close an IndiaMART lead, without competing for the lead itself.
- Chartered accountants who advise MSMEs, as a referral channel for GST-clean invoices and payment safety.
- Short Tamil and English videos on avoiding advance-payment loss, plus template pages (job-work agreement, milestone contract) for search traffic.

Plan	Price	What it includes
Free	₹0	Unlimited deal rooms, offers, chat, OTP-signed agreements and basic verification
Protected payment fee	1.5% of each funded milestone, minimum ₹49, maximum ₹4,999, plus GST	Held payment, release, dispute handling. Refunded if the deal is cancelled before release

Plan	Price	What it includes
Payment cost	At actuals, shown before paying	Razorpay's standard rate is 2% plus GST, including UPI; it offers custom pricing to funded startups and businesses above about ₹5 lakh a month (Razorpay pricing)
Business Pro	₹999 a month per business, 3 seats	1% fee instead of 1.5%, GST invoices, deal templates, team roles, analytics, priority disputes

Unit economics for a ₹1,00,000 deal funded by UPI at standard rates (my estimate): our fee is ₹1,500 plus ₹270 GST, and payment cost is ₹2,000 plus ₹360 GST, so the all-in cost is ₹4,130, or 4.1%. That sits near Escrow.com's 2.6% plus a 3.05% card surcharge and above Trustap's 2–4% buyer fee, so custom aggregator pricing and bank-transfer funding for B2B tickets are early priorities.

After about ₹300 of variable cost per deal (identity checks, SMS and WhatsApp, AI, support), each such deal contributes about ₹1,200. About 100 funded deals a month cover a ₹1.2 lakh monthly cost base. The ₹4,999 cap keeps large B2B orders cheap: on a ₹10 lakh order our fee is 0.5%.

Regulatory and compliance audit (India)

The product is legal to build as designed, provided the platform never holds money itself and handles GST, TDS, consumer and data rules from day one. Each rule below becomes a concrete build requirement in the Claude Code prompt.

Area	What the rule says	What it means for HaathMila	What we build
Holding money	RBI's Payment Aggregator directions (15 Sep 2025): non-bank aggregators need RBI authorisation and ₹15 crore net worth, keep funds in escrow at a scheduled commercial bank, settle only to merchants' own accounts, and marketplaces may collect only for sellers registered on them (Medianama)	We stay a marketplace merchant of an authorised aggregator, never an aggregator ourselves	Seller onboarding with KYC before the first payout; payouts only to the seller's verified account; no cash on delivery
GST as an e-commerce operator	An operator that collects consideration for supplies made through it collects TCS at 0.5% from 10 July 2024 under Section 52 (TaxGuru)	Funded B2B deals likely make us an e-commerce operator. Personal used-goods sales between individuals are a separate case	TCS ledger on seller payouts, monthly statement export, GST on our own fee, GST invoices
Income-tax TDS	Section 393(1), table item 8(v) of the Income-tax Act 2025 replaced Section 194-O from 1 April 2026: 0.1% of gross sales, none for individuals or HUFs up to ₹5 lakh a year who give PAN or Aadhaar (TDSMAN)	Every payout needs the seller's PAN and a TDS check	PAN capture, TDS engine on payouts, quarterly statement export, certificates

Area	What the rule says	What it means for HaathMila	What we build
Electronic agreements	IT Act Section 10A makes electronic contracts valid; Section 5 equates recognised e-signatures with handwritten ones; OTP and click-to-accept rely on Section 10A plus clear evidence of consent; wills, trust deeds and most powers of attorney are excluded (Leegality)	OTP signing works for commercial deals if consent is clearly recorded; Aadhaar eSign adds weight for large deals	Hashed PDF, OTP signature with time, IP and device; Aadhaar eSign through a licensed provider in phase 2; real-estate sales out of scope
Aadhaar and identity	Since 2025, private entities can apply for Aadhaar authentication through the relevant ministry, with UIDAI examination (Medianama)	We should not run Aadhaar authentication ourselves	KYC through a licensed provider or DigiLocker; store status and reference IDs only, never Aadhaar numbers
Consumer protection	E-Commerce Rules 2020: grievance officer acknowledges complaints in 48 hours and resolves in one month; seller details, refund and payment terms on display; explicit consent, no pre-ticked boxes; no one-sided cancellation charges (Khaitan & Co)	Applies once consumers transact on the platform	Grievance page and ticket SLA timers, seller details in every deal room, explicit consent checkboxes, symmetric cancellation rules

Area	What the rule says	What it means for HaathMila	What we build
Dark patterns	CCPA's 2023 guidelines list 13 dark patterns, including false urgency and drip pricing; a June 2025 advisory asked platforms to self-audit within three months and self-declare (Lok Sabha reply)	Honest negotiation is also a selling point	Real offer expiry only, all fees shown before commitment, no pre-ticked add-ons, yearly self-audit checklist
Data protection	DPDP Rules notified 13 Nov 2025: consent-manager provisions from Nov 2026; notice, consent, security, breach notification and retention duties from May 2027 (AZB & Partners)	Build compliant now rather than retrofit in 2027	Consent records, purpose-specific notices, data export and deletion, retention schedule, breach runbook, data stored in India
UPI limits	Regular UPI stays at ₹1 lakh; higher ₹5 lakh limits apply only to verified merchants in specified categories (News On AIR)	Large B2B milestones cannot rely on UPI	Netbanking and NEFT/RTGS funding for big tickets; split large orders into milestones

I'm not a lawyer or chartered accountant. Before launch, have a fintech lawyer confirm the Razorpay marketplace structure and a CA confirm the GST and TDS treatment, especially whether the platform counts as an agent.

Risks and mitigations

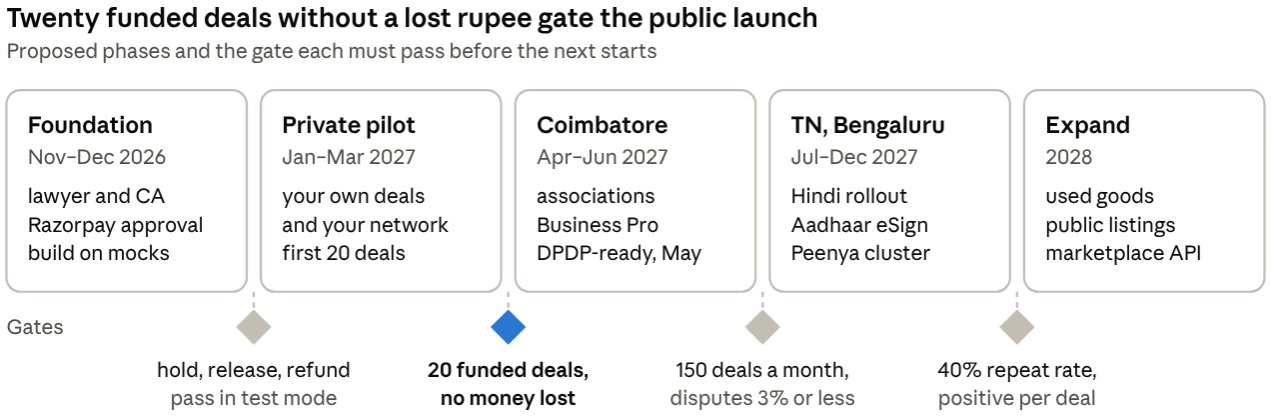
The biggest risks are adoption, not technology: getting the other party to join, and getting strong buyers to fund before delivery. Payment-partner and fraud risks come next and must be handled before launch.

Risk	Severity	Mitigation	Early warning
Cold start: neither side wants to be first on a new platform	High	Deal links that open without signup, OTP to accept, your own ElectronIx deals first, launch through associations	Under 40% of invited counterparties join within 7 days
Strong buyers refuse to pre-fund	High	Partial holds (for example 30% of the advance), a "get paid on time" pitch to suppliers, milestone templates for job work	Share of deals stuck at "Agreed" without funding
Payment partner limits or freezes the account	High	Written approval for the held-payment use case before launch; a provider adapter so a second aggregator can be added	Any risk review or settlement delay from Razorpay
Fraud on the platform: fake sellers, mule accounts, collusive refunds	High	KYC and bank-account name match before payout, longer holds for new sellers, velocity limits, manual review above a threshold	Disputes per 100 funded deals; refund rate by seller cohort
Dispute handling costs more than the fee	Medium	Evidence locker, structured claims, inspection windows with auto-release, an ODR partner for large cases	Support minutes per funded deal
Tax or regulatory reclassification	Medium	Lawyer and CA opinions before launch; TCS and TDS built in from day one	Any notice, or a change in the aggregator's terms

Risk	Severity	Mitigation	Early warning
Incumbents copy the idea (IndiaMART adds held payments, Trustap adds Indian sellers)	Medium	Depth of the deal room, portable reputation, Tamil and Hindi first, MSME templates; partner where possible	A competitor launch in India
AI copilot gives bad advice or leaks private limits	Medium	Suggestions only; one side's private notes never enter the other side's AI context; logged prompts; a human confirms every offer	AI-related complaints
Small-team bandwidth	Medium	Narrow MVP, managed services (Supabase, Vercel, Razorpay), a part-time mediator for disputes	Release cadence slipping past two weeks

Roadmap, MVP scope and success metrics

The MVP is the complete trusted deal loop for B2B and project deals, with nothing extra: negotiate, sign, fund, deliver, release, review. Everything else waits until 20 real funded deals have closed without a rupee lost.



roadmap · 5 phases, 4 gates (proposed)

Each phase starts only when the gate before it passes; the dates assume work starts in November 2026.

In the MVP:

- Phone OTP and email login, personal and business profiles, GSTIN on business accounts.
- Verification: PAN and bank-account check through a KYC provider adapter (a mock in development).
- Three deal templates: goods order, job work or project with milestones, freelance service.
- Deal room: versioned offers and counters with a diff, expiry, chat, attachments, scam shield.
- Agreement PDF generated from the accepted offer, OTP signing, SHA-256 fingerprint.
- Funding through Razorpay with held transfers, milestone release, refunds, delivery proof, inspection window with auto-release.
- Disputes v1 with admin mediation; verified, double-blind reviews; public trust profile.
- Admin console: KYC queue, disputes, payouts, audit log. Notifications in-app, by email, and through an SMS and WhatsApp adapter.
- English and Tamil interface; AI copilot v1 (summary, counter suggestion inside a private limit, risk flags, translation).

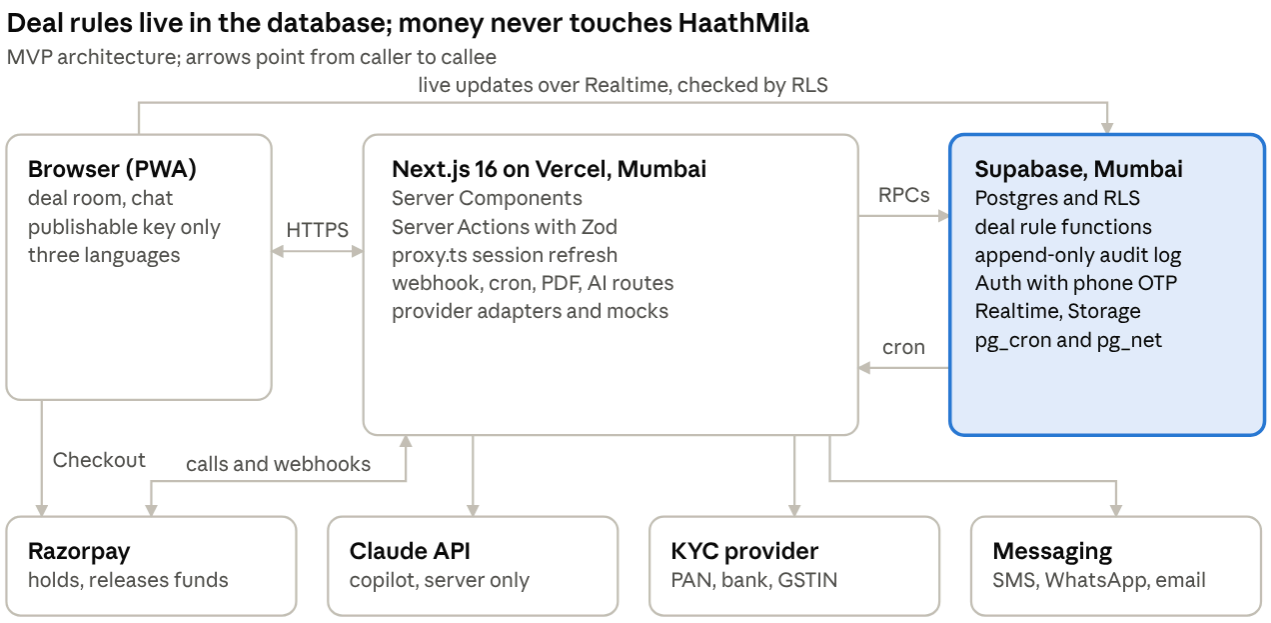
Later: public listings, Aadhaar eSign, used goods between individuals with inspection and logistics partners, Hindi, native mobile apps (a PWA comes first), a marketplace API, and agent-to-agent negotiation.

Metric (pilot, first 6 months)	Target	Why it matters
Funded deals per month by month 6	150	Proves people pay for protection
Invited counterparties who join within 7 days	60% or more	Health of the deal-link growth loop
Signed agreements that get funded	50% or more	Shows buyers accept held payment
Median time from first offer to signed agreement	48 hours or less	Structure should speed deals up, not slow them
Disputes per 100 funded deals	3 or fewer, median resolution within 7 days	Keeps support cost below the fee
Money lost to fraud	₹0	The core promise
Businesses closing a second deal within 60 days	40% or more	Real retention, not curiosity

These targets are my proposal for a pilot, not benchmarks from a source.

Build approach: Next.js and Supabase

One Next.js 16 app on Vercel talks to one Supabase project in Mumbai. All money moves through Razorpay, and every deal rule lives in Postgres functions guarded by row-level security. The Claude Code prompt that comes with this report builds it in nine phases, each ending with tests and a stop for your review.



An eSign provider joins in phase 2 behind the same adapter pattern.

architecture · 3 core parts, 4 external services

The browser reads live updates straight from Supabase under row-level security; every write and every call to an outside service goes through the Next.js server.

The decisions that shape the build:

- Rules in the database. Every state change (offer, accept, sign, fund, deliver, release, dispute) is a Postgres function that checks the caller, writes the audit log and fails closed, so the interface cannot skip a step.
- Row-level security on every table, including a private-notes table only its owner can read. The browser uses Supabase's publishable key, secret keys stay on the server, pages are protected with getClaims(), and session refresh runs in proxy.ts, as Supabase's current Next.js guide prescribes (Supabase docs).
- Adapters for everything external: payments (mock and Razorpay), KYC, SMS and WhatsApp, email, eSign and AI. The whole product runs end to end on mocks, so it can be built and tested before any account is approved.
- Money as whole paise in integers, one fee function with unit tests, verified and idempotent webhooks, and held transfers released through Razorpay's settlement-hold API (Razorpay docs).
- Agreements as PDFs with Tamil and Devanagari fonts, a SHA-256 fingerprint and a signature page.
- Scheduled jobs (offer expiry, auto-release, reminders) on Supabase cron, so nothing depends on a paid Vercel plan.
- AI calls only from the server, using the requesting user's own permissions, so the other side's private data never reaches the model.

- Windows-friendly: every command runs in PowerShell, with no bash-only scripts. CLAUDE.md, docs/SPEC.md and docs/DECISIONS.md keep Claude Code's context across sessions and milestones.

Next.js 16 has been the current major since 22 October 2025, and 16.4.3 was the latest release on 29 October 2026 (versio.io). The prompt tells Claude Code to check current official docs and to log any deviation in docs/DECISIONS.md.

Sources

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- MediaBrief: Recordent Indian SME Receivables Report 2026
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Competitors

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- versio.io: Next.js releases